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LONG BEFORE HE JOINED Accel as its first Associate in India, Abhishek Goyal was working as a software developer at Amazon Development Centre (India). Working for an online retailer that has become one of the biggest globally, Goyal understood the concept of e-commerce long before it was a thing in India. The experience of working with Amazon came in handy when, two months after joining venture capital (VC) major Accel, Goyal met Sachin and Binny Bansal in March 2008 at an Open Coffee Club event in Bengaluru, which is an informal gathering of start-up founders, wannabe entrepreneurs, angel investors and VCs to

India, Goyal brought the Co-founders and their then obscure company, Flipkart, to the notice of Subrata Mitra, Prashanth Prakash, Mahendran Balachandran and Gagan Kumar. The quartet became Partners at the rebranded entity in 2008 when their \$10-million early-stage fund called Erasmic Venture Fund came under the aegis of the global VC giant, that was looking to have a presence in India's nascent start-up ecosystem.

Following a string of meetings at Accel's office in Bengaluru, and the Bansals' two-bedroom apartment-turned-office-space, Accel wrote an \$800,000 seed cheque for the company in October 2009. And the rest, as they say, is history.

"Flipkart was already live. Having worked at Amazon earlier, I realised they were building the Amazon of India. I knew how big it could become. If Amazon is so big in the US, an Indian version of it could become meaningfully larger, because offline retail is so much more broken in India. We don't have large retail chains like they have in the US, and therefore, e-commerce could have deeper pen-

invested in a slew of online ventures such as babycare products retailer BabyOye; online electronic goods retailer Letsbuy, medical consultation and referral portal HealthcareMagic, and online entertainment community Chakpak in keeping with its investment thesis of investing early in e-commerce start-ups that show potential.

"Our goal is to be the first partner of choice for founders, and we want to be with the best technology companies globally. We are conservative in the sense that, given our early-stage DNA, we are rooted to the ground, and understand what the founder needs. In most cases, when we first meet a founder, the business typically doesn't exist. We are very real about where the business starts from, and we are equally aware that these businesses can become very large. That's the balance in our approach," says Abhinav Chaturvedi, a Partner at Accel who focusses on early-stage start-ups in the consumer, fintech and software-as-a-service (SaaS) segments.

With its early identification the-

AT ACCEL, EACH PARTNER PICKS UP AREAS THAT THEY THINK ARE INTERESTING, WORKS ON IT, BUILDS A THESIS AROUND IT OVER A PERIOD OF TIME, AND INVESTS IN AREAS WHERE A LOT OF INTERESTING COMPANIES ARE EMERGING

meet and talk shop on weekends.

Goyal's interaction with the two Bansals (not related) informed him that they were building an online bookstore, which immediately reminded him of Amazon that had started out similarly. The short but in-depth conversation with the Bansals was enough to convince Goyal of the potential of what they were creating, and where it could go.

Although early days for Accel in

etration. That was my thesis," says Goyal about Flipkart. Later, Goyal founded data analytics firm Tracxn, where Accel is an investor.

Seeing Flipkart's strong growth rates, e-commerce became an investment thesis at Accel. The VC major went after the category, vertical by vertical, after its investment in the e-commerce major fructified beautifully. In the subsequent months and years, it identified and

sis, Accel has become the first institutional investor in over 85 per cent of its investments in India and Southeast Asia, with 95 per cent of its investments made during a start-up's seed or series A round.

But e-commerce is not the only space where the fund has created a winning thesis. Similar to how the company built a thesis around its Flipkart investment, Accel has also created a view on the SaaS segment